

DON'T DIE RETIRED

The 7-Day Restart Plan

One week of ten-minute movements to prove to yourself you can start

Free starter plan · Free for newsletter readers

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This guide is general information, not medical advice. Check with your GP or a health professional before starting a new exercise programme, especially if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure, joint problems or have been inactive for a long time. Stop and seek advice if anything hurts.

Welcome — and well done for opening this

Most people who mean to get more active never begin, because the first step looks too big. This plan makes it small: seven days, ten minutes each, nothing to buy, nothing to be good at. At the end you will know something about yourself that you cannot know today.

You do not need to be fit, thin, sporty or brave. You need a sturdy chair, a worktop or wall to hold, comfortable shoes and ten minutes. If you have knees that grumble or a back that stiffens, that is normal and you are exactly who this is for.

Before you start

If you have a heart condition, uncontrolled blood pressure, have fainted or had chest pain in the last year, have had a fall in the last six months or have been told to avoid exercise, have a quick word with your GP or practice nurse first. This is a gentle programme and most will be pleased.

Stop and rest if you feel chest pain or tightness, sudden breathlessness that does not settle, faintness, or sharp pain in a joint. Ordinary next-day muscle ache is fine; it means you did something.

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Day 0 — two numbers to write down

1. **Sit-to-stand.** From a firm chair, arms crossed if you can, stand fully and sit fully as many times as you comfortably can in 30 seconds. Count them. Using your hands is allowed; note it.
2. **How do you feel today?** Score yourself 1 to 10, where 1 is stiff, tired and unsteady and 10 is loose and sure-footed. First instinct.

	Day 0	Day 7
Sit-to-stands in 30 seconds		
How I feel (1–10)		

The movements

Movement	How
Ankle pumps	Seated. Point toes away, then pull them up towards you. Slow and full.
Seated march	Seated, tall. Lift one knee a little, lower, then the other.
Knee extension	Seated. Straighten one knee until the leg is level, hold a breath, lower slowly.
Shoulder rolls	Roll shoulders up, back and down in a slow circle.
Sit-to-stand	Feet flat, slightly back. Lean forward, stand, lower slowly. Hands if needed.
Heel raises	Standing, holding support. Rise onto the toes, pause, lower slowly.
Side leg raise	Standing, holding support. Lift one leg out to the side without leaning. Lower with control.
Mini squat	Standing, holding support, chair behind you. Bend knees part way as if to sit, stand back up.
Wall push-up	Hands on wall at shoulder height, feet a stride back. Chest towards wall, push away.
Single-leg stand	Hand on support. Lift one foot a little and hold, looking at a fixed point.
Marching on the spot	Standing, hand near support. Lift knees alternately.
Walk	Indoors or out, at a pace where you could still talk.

Your seven days

Day	Do this	Done / how did it feel?
Day 1	Ankle pumps ×10 each, shoulder rolls ×8, seated march ×20, knee extension ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×3 (10 min)	☐ Slow counts. Today is about turning up.
Day 2	Seated march ×20, knee extension ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×4, heel raises at the chair ×8, shoulder rolls ×8 (10 min)	☐ Lower into the chair slowly — that is where strength is built.
Day 3	Sit-to-stand ×5, heel raises ×10, side leg raise ×6 each, marching on the spot 1 min, single-leg stand 5 sec each with hand on (10 min)	☐ Both hands on the worktop. Nothing to prove.
Day 4	Mini squat ×6, wall push-up ×8, heel raises ×10, seated march ×20, sit-to-stand ×5 (10 min)	☐ Mini squat: weight in the heels, chest up.
Day 5	Marching on the spot 1 min, indoor or outdoor walk 4 min, side leg raise ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min)	☐ A pace where you could hum a tune.
Day 6	Sit-to-stand ×6, mini squat ×8, wall push-up ×10, single-leg stand 8 sec each, heel raises ×12 (10 min)	☐ Try the single-leg stand with two fingertips instead of a full hand.
Day 7	Retest: sit-to-stands in 30 seconds, and your 1–10 score. Then a 6-minute walk somewhere you like (10 min)	☐ Write the Day 7 numbers in the table. Compare.

If a day goes wrong

Do the two-minute version and still tick the box: sit-to-stand ×3, heel raises ×10, march for 30 seconds, one slow breath. The habit matters more than any single day.

What your Day 7 numbers mean

Most people add one to three sit-to-stands in a week — partly stronger legs, mostly the body remembering how. The feel-score usually moves more. Neither number is the point. The point is that you did seven days, which most people never do, and you now know the ten minutes fits in your life.

What next

- **Keep going with The 30-Day Restart** (£9 at dontdieretired.com/shop). It picks up exactly here: four weeks from chair to standing to walking to stairs, with a self-test at each end and a two-minute fallback for bad days.
- **Already steady on your feet?** Go straight to **Strong at 60**, our 12-week beginner strength plan for home or gym — the twice-a-week strength work that the UK Chief Medical Officers recommend and fewer than one in three over-65s actually do.
- **Read a story a day.** Every morning at dontdieretired.com we publish a real, sourced story of someone over 50 who started something — a marathon at 70, a doctorate at 80, a surfboard at 60 — with one small thing you can try.

“You do not have to be good at this. You just have to turn up for ten minutes, and then turn up again tomorrow.” — Don't Die Retired